

DRIVING ACTIONS WITH DATA

Navigating the Data Roadmap: Which Prioritization Framework Actually Works?

From Now/Next/Later for high-velocity chaos to Portfolio Management for ROI – a decision tree for the modern Data Leader.



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APR 14, 2026



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CFO corners me: “Why are there millions of euros burned on data with zero ROI?”

In the first week of onboarding, I wasn’t just learning the tech stack; I was firefighting a million-euro reporting gap and a public ‘very sloppy’ reprimand from the CEO. The order was nonexistent. Prioritization wasn’t just a goal; it was a survival mechanism.

Drawing on my experience at two EU-listed firms, it was overwhelming - the next things were happening already before I could even grasp what was happening. Even though it was just the first week of my onboarding, I felt strongly compelled to bring order to chaos.

That means Prioritization.

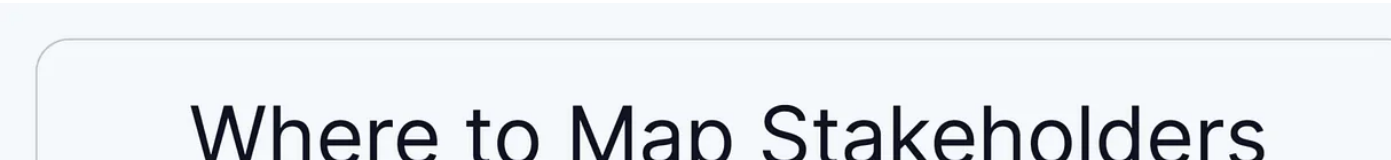
Prioritization means knowing what actually matters, mapping out stakeholders (and which of them actually call the shots), and bringing visibility to both the team and stakeholders **at scale**.

Only when the above were nailed, could we confidently say “no” to requests.

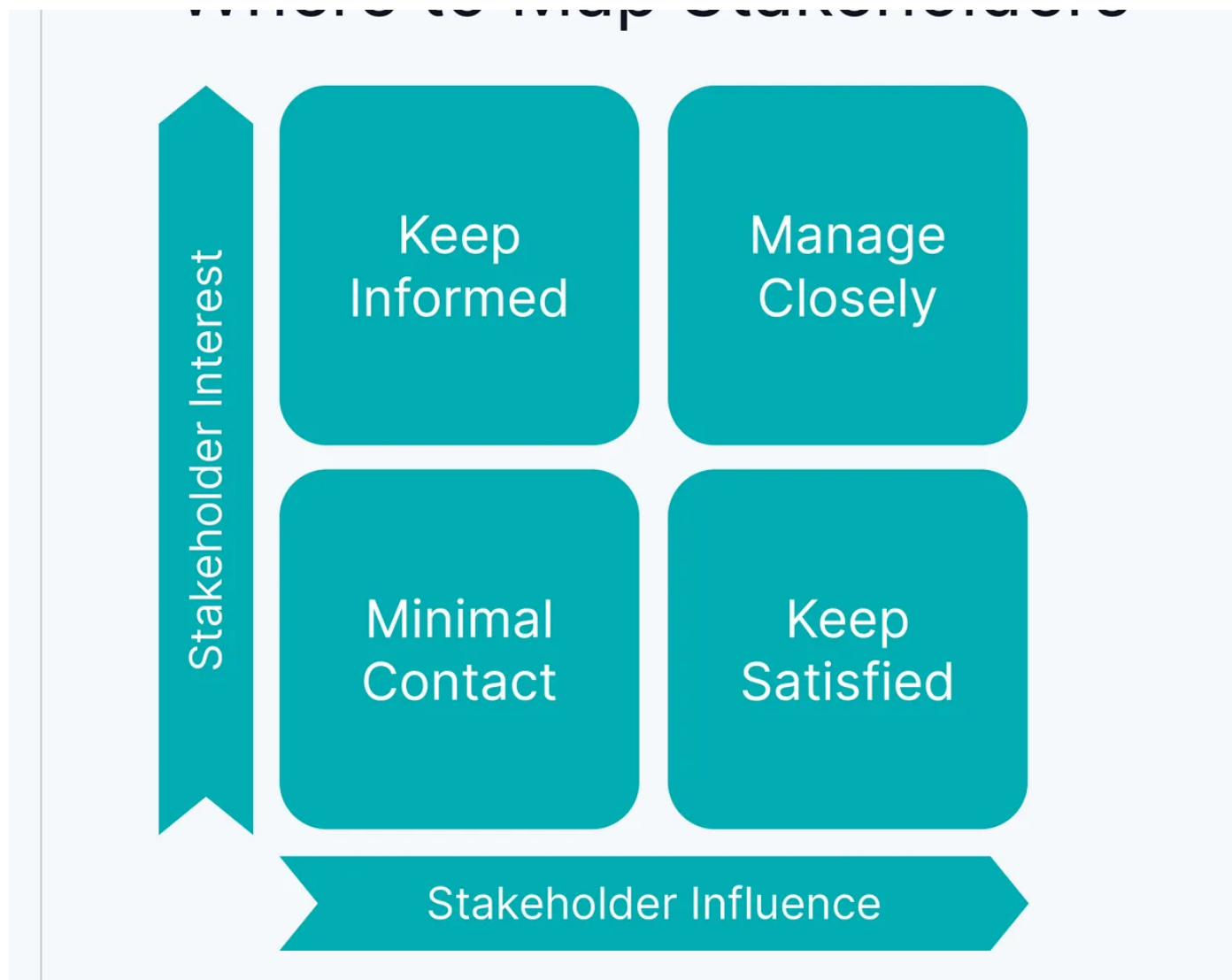
Groundwork - Stakeholder Mapping

This was my first attempt to build more structure and predictability for the stakeholders and the team.

Like old school Business Administration teachings about PPT - People, Process, Tools. **The most critical part is People**, always



Where to Map Stakeholders



Stakeholder Power-Interest Grid, and the respective approach for them

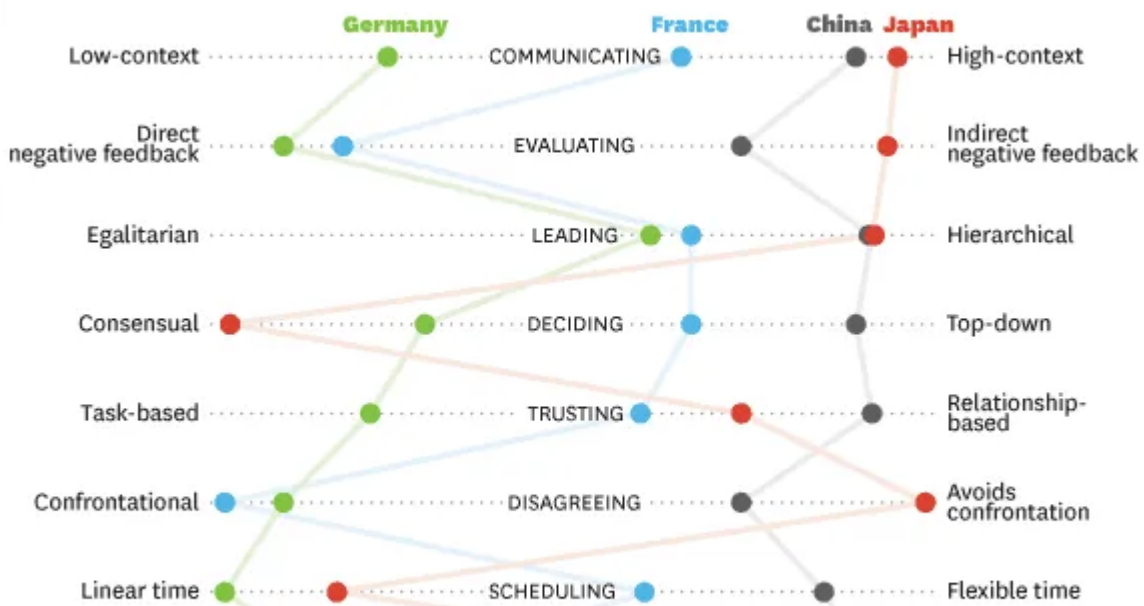
At the end of scanning the org chart and handshake sessions, I have mapped these people in my stakeholder map in the Vestiaire context:

- **Manage Closely (High Power & High Interest):** Top veto + power users
 - Business:
 - The COO & VP Ops Performance
 - Data: The Ops analysts
- **Keep Satisfied (High Power & Low Interest):**

- Product Director
- CTO and the other executives
- **Keep Informed (Low Power & High Interest): Heavy users without veto**
 - The relevant Operations team leads (e.g., Carrier Managers, Project Managers, and Warehouse Leadership)
 - Product Analytics
- **Secondary stakeholders (Low Power & Low Interest): Rare interacting parties**
 - Product Managers
 - Sustainability Team

If one works long enough in data and tech, the data leader would know the importance of looping in the senior leaders in the stakeholders (e.g., the COO among the Ops stakeholders, the Product Director among the PMs, etc.) as it will be critical in the later stage of prioritization regardless of which framework being used especially in higher power distance culture like French.

MANAGEMENT STYLES ACROSS FOUR DIFFERENT CULTURES





The Cultural Map from Erin Meyer, with Germany, France, China and Japan as the example. At the “Deciding” dimension, France is leaning towards “Top-down” polar.

Employees usually don’t really like “The big boss says so”. But when it comes to prioritization, it is a vital part of keeping a request list ordered and stable.

Framework 1: Quarterly Roadmap

Once the stakeholders’ mapping is clear, the next step is to draft a simple Google Sheet for stakeholders to submit their asks for the next quarter. The exact columns could vary, but what is really important to capture would be:

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1		Filled by Stakeholders					
2	Date	Requestor	Title	Description	Business Impact	Expected Deliverables/Spec	Expected End
3	2026-04-01	COO	Ops AI POC	xyz	- Free up human capacity in Ops	Up & Running POC of the AI agent	H1
4	2026-04-15	Ops team	New data marts for CS Chatbot	xyz	- Visibility of benchmark between human CS agent vs AI	New data marts	Apr
5	2026-03-14	Tech	Ingest from new Kafka topics	xyz	- Able to analyze the impact of new microservice	New tables in ODS	ASAP

Example Quarterly Roadmap in Google Sheet

The above could only come from the stakeholders.

A mass email to stakeholders would be sent out around 2-3 weeks before the cutoff date of roadmap items submission. Then the last reminder email would be sent 1 week before the cutoff date, followed by the last email at the cutoff date.

Then, enter the Grooming stage.

The data team must make sure the following are filled by them (NO

by the stakeholders):

A	B	C	I	J	K	L
	Filled by Stakeholder		<i>Filled by Data Team</i>			
<u>Date</u>	<u>Requestor</u>	<u>Title</u>	<u>Estimated Effort</u>	<u>Comments</u>	<u>Decision</u>	<u>EPIC</u>
2026-04-01	COO	Ops AI POC	XL		Accepted ▾	
2026-04-15	Ops team	New data marts for CS Chatbot	XS		Adhoc ▾	
2026-03-14	Tech	Ingest from new Kafka topics	S	Can be done with Grafana instead	Rejected ▾	

Example Grooming columns from the Data team

1. Estimated Effort: could be t-shirt sizes (e.g. S, M, L, XL, etc.), or more business friendly terms (e.g. 3-4 weeks, 1 mon etc.)
 - a. Important note: always under promise and over deliver!
2. Decision: (assuming the data team has enough information)
 - a. Accepted
 - b. Rejected, with suggested alternatives:
 - c. Adhoc: The effort required and risk are low enough to be considered as an adhoc request
3. Link to relevant EPIC or ticket: for stakeholders to keep themselves informed once the project is accepted

There could be a few back & forth with different stakeholders at this stage for gaining more information, and usually the senior leaders from stakeholders would be involved for competing priorities.

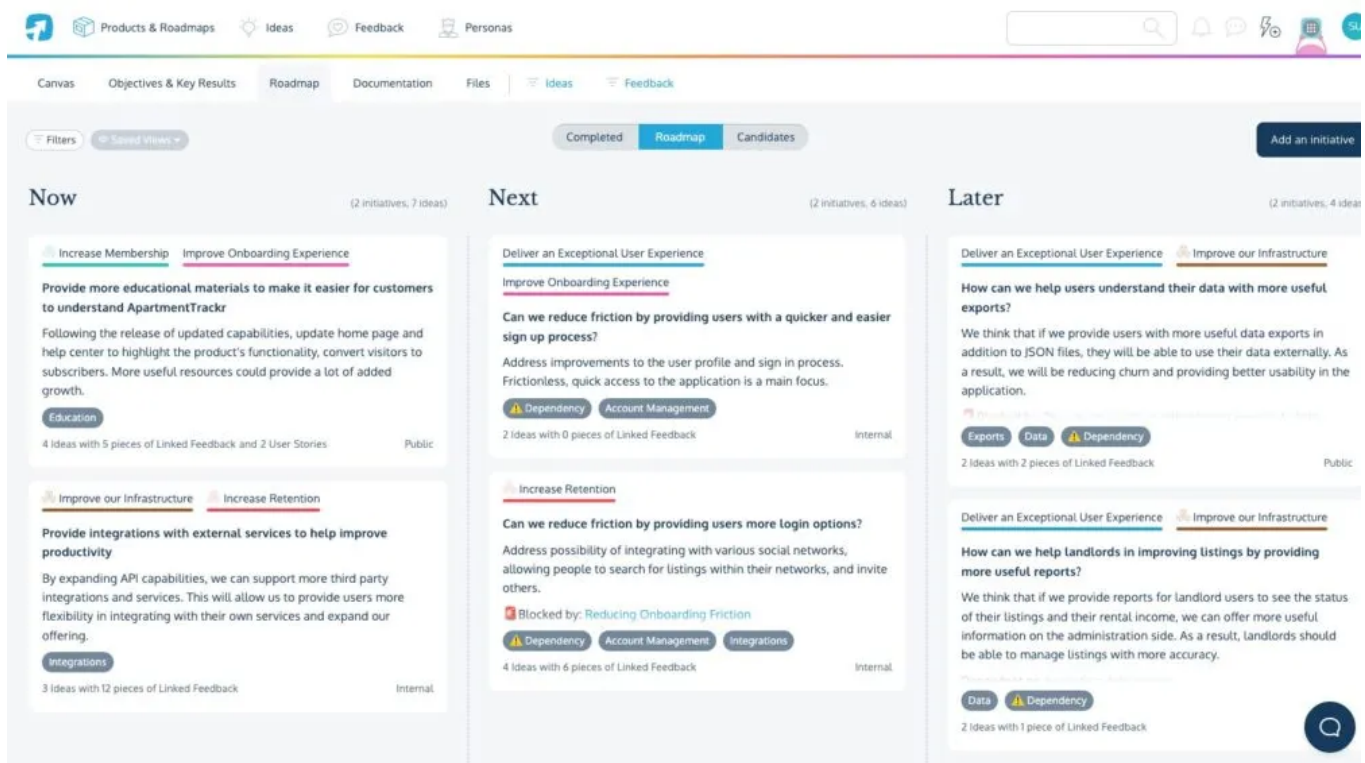
The whole point of having this Quarterly Roadmap is to bring **visibility to an overview of all requests and asks from all stakeholders**. It will give a very good sense of what is in the headspace of the stakeholder, and how much wiggle room there is in inserting your own roadmap items.

I've done this for a few quarters - it took some time for the stakeholders to adopt. It took some educational and communication effort at the beginning, but it paid off pretty soon, as well as bought much wanted clarity to both data teams and also stakeholders.

Knowing what to expect at what time is vital for stakeholders, especially business stakeholders.

Framework 2: Now/Next/Later – For High-Velocity Chaos

As the business dynamic evolves and the change of leadership in tech, Vestiaire also pivoted into a company level prioritization framework: Now/Next/Later.



An example of a Now/Next/Later roadmap

Invented by [ProdPad's Janna Bastow](#) for unpredictable roadmaps. Buckets projects into **NOW** (committed, 1-3 months), **NEXT** (planned, 3-6 months), **LATER** (ideas, 6+ months). No fake dates – flexibility rules.

After some initial adoption friction, NNL has gained some good traction. It worked especially nicely for me, as it felt like a monthly version of Scrum – the only difference is grooming on project level instead of the ticket level.

Why NNL was welcomed:

- **Dead Simple:** for stakeholders, NOW means this month, NEXT means next month, and LATER means backlog – which means more curating needed or could be dropped if needed. Straightforward. Not much room for misunderstanding.
- **Agile Mate:** NNL works a lot like Scrum in action. So these 2 methodologies are naturally compatible.
- **Capacity Lock:** There was a constraint implied that 1 individual could only take 2 NOW projects per month max, in order to maintain focus and quality of deliverables. It also protects team from burnout. It also leaves out around 20% buffer for bugs & incidents, potentially could also add 5% buffer for learning R&D.
- **Expectations Management:** The NNL board is publicly visible to everyone, and stakeholders know what to expect and also avoid the “why not me?” fights.
- **Pivot Fast:** NNL exercises happen on a monthly basis, which allows good pivoting flexibility without trading off too much quality of the project.

Trade-offs & considerations:

1. **Great for small to mid-size companies** (e.g., from 10-500 FTEs **volatile business** (e.g., Retail, Fashion industry), or **uncert times** (e.g., US tariff hitting US market performance, geopolitical conflicts, etc.).
2. **Heavy projects are almost impossible to get prioritized:** Any projects that take more than a month almost never beat the qu wins and low-hanging fruits.
3. **Institutional Amnesia:** Fast iteration also means the people w forget what happened in the past quickly, which would make it harder for the momentum to accumulate to a meaningful volume and this doesn't help programs like data/AI literacy programs or foundational work with no obvious and immediate business impact (e.g., refactoring vs new features)
4. **Fast Tech Debt accumulation:** the data and tech teams are unde more pressure to borrow tech debts in order to move fast

Framework 3: Portfolio Prioritization – Investment Mindset for Predictable Scale

Best for: Mature organizations (400-20k FTEs) or high-scrutiny environments (e.g., Banking, Healthcare, or CFO-led).

If>NNL is about **velocity**, Portfolio Prioritization is about **yield**. This is the framework to use when the CFO starts asking, “*What is the ROI of our 40-person data org?*” In this model, the Data Leader acts as a portfolio manager. You don't just look at a list of tickets; you look at “Asset Classes.”

[The Best Engineers Think Like Investors, Not Builders.](#) -

Michael Lin

The same goes for Data Leaders - The best data leaders think like Portfolio Managers.

While few public blueprints exist for Portfolios, the Amazon 6-pager remains the gold standard for high-stakes capital allocation. The closest thing would be [the Amazon 6-pager](#). Treat data project as an **investment portfolio**: Expected ROI vs. resource cost (eng weeks, tools). Quarterly rebalance like stocks.

Amazon's 6-Pager Memo Method

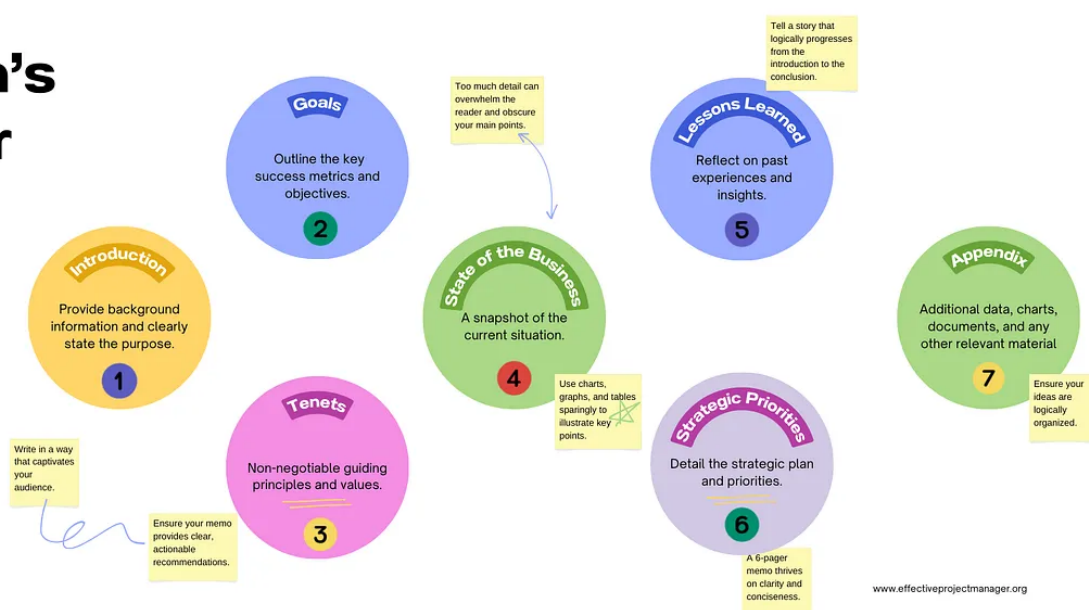


Illustration from [The Effective Project Manager](#).

Core idea: Data VP as portfolio manager. Stakeholders would draft White Paper (i.e., the 6-pager) per project with introduction, goals, tenets, State of the Business, Lessons, Learning, and Strategic Priorities. Projects compete for finite capacity (e.g., data engineers + 1 analyst FTEs/quarter). All relevant parties are putting heads together in an “In-take” session to iron out all details. At the end of it, there would be a ranked list of candidates waiting to be worked on.

To manage at scale, bucket your capacity:

- **Core / Run (40%):** KTLO, compliance, and tech debt. The “Tax” pay to operate.
- **Grow (40%):** ROI-driven optimizations (e.g., churn models). The “Income.”
- **Transform (20%):** High-risk AI R&D. Your “Call Options” on the future.

This allows you to defend a “No” by showing the balance: “We can do your dashboard without selling our AI capacity.”

Why for data leaders:

- **Battle-tested in the European tech scene:** Portfolio is a natural evolution from the Amazon 6-pager in Zalando SE (a EU standard listed company with 10-20k FTEs globally), and it got adopted again in Vestiaire
- **Crystal Clear ROIs & ETAs:** “Project X: €1.5M uplift, 8 weeks. Beats Project Y’s €800k/12 weeks.”
- **Org design tie-in:** Scales to 200+ teams – allocate % capacity Growth/Defence/Innovation buckets.
- **Well protection for scarce data and engineering capacity:** exceptionally useful when there are loud stakeholders who keep making quick and difficult decision requests. The 6-pager for them to rethink the ROI of their requests

Trade-offs:

- **Overhead high:** business cases take time to make.
- **Gold for mature orgs:** Recommended for organizations with 400- or even more FTEs.

- **Require predictability in business:** a volatile market environment would let opportunities slip by before the process is done
- **Org Maturity needed as well:** Portfolio is for sure only for mature organizations. It will be a weak starter for unstructured teams as it would be too much bureaucracy for them.

There will be a separate article for the Amazon 6-pager - stay tuned for future updates.

Framework Comparison: Your Decision Matrix

Choosing a framework is a strategic decision in itself. As a Data Leader, you aren't just picking a tool; you're picking the **operating system** for your department. Use this matrix for your next internal alignment or CDO-level strategy session:

Dimension	1. Quarterly Roadmap	2. Now/Next/Later	3. Portfolio
Primary Goal	Alignment & Deadlines	Velocity & Focus	<u>Yield & Capacity Defense</u>
Business Pace	Predictable (Fixed cycles)	Volatile (Fast pivoting)	Long-term (Strategic bets)
Org Maturity	Low-Med (Transitioning)	Med-High (Agile/Scale)	High (Enterprise/ROI-driven)
Overhead	Medium (Planning weeks)	Low (Monthly curation)	High (6-pagers & Reviews)
CFO Buy-In	Low (Visibility only)	Medium (Trust-based)	High (P&L Quantified)
The "Vibe"	"What's the plan?"	"What's the priority?"	"What's the ROI?"
Primary Failure Mode	Fails when the market moves faster than 90 days	Fails when leadership demands a "hard launch date" for a marketing campaign.	Fails when the "overhead" of writing a 6-pager exceeds the value of the small project.

The Executive Decision Tree

1. **Just starting to bring order to chaos?** Start with the **Quarter Roadmap**. It's the "Gateway Drug" to prioritization that gets stakeholders used to committing to a plan.
2. **Does your roadmap feel "fake" or out-of-date by week 3?** Shift **Now/Next/Later**. It trades false precision for high-velocity focus.
3. **Are you fighting for budget or defending headcount?** Graduate **Portfolio**. Use the 6-pager to transform data requests into business investment cases.
4. **Pro-Tip:** No matter the framework, always document the **"Why"** in narrative format. A written page beats a slide deck every time when it comes to defending a "No."

Trade-offs & The "Real World" Check

No framework is a silver bullet. You have to "pay" for the benefits:

- **Quarterly Roadmaps:** Provide great visibility, but often turn into "Wishlists" that never get updated. **Fix:** Be ruthless at 6-week mark – cut what isn't moving.
- **Now/Next/Later:** Excellent for morale and autonomy, but the C-levels will hate the lack of hard dates. **Fix:** Add quarterly R "gates" to check progress against the bottom line.
- **Portfolio:** Provides ultimate rigor, but it can slow down innovation. **Fix:** Use a hybrid approach – Portfolio for the 70% "Big Bets," and NNL for the 30% "Quick Wins."

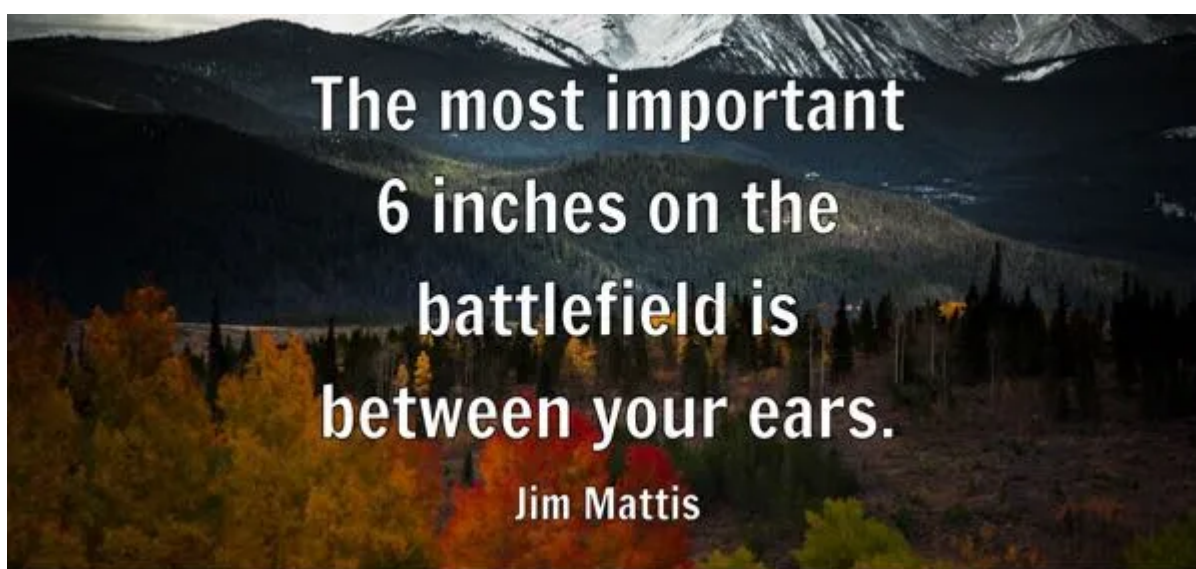
Outro: Judgement's call

The age of AI doesn't erase the importance of human judgment. On the contrary, it makes it critical.

Building things has become easier and cheaper, but that is a trap when you can "have it all," you end up with everything and nothing – cluttered roadmaps and diluted impact. In 2026, the competitive advantage isn't the ability to build more; it's **the ability to decide what is worth building**.

Prioritization frameworks are ultimately just tools. The real skill is knowing the difference between what is "urgent" and what is "important," and when to move fast versus when to move deep.

Tools provide the data, but the leader makes the call.



Quote from Jim Mattis, retired U.S. Marine Corps general and former Secretary of Defense. Image from [BrainyQuote](#),



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